



Unkind cuts

The scale of ECI's deletions in Telangana and Karnataka needs explanation

The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process being conducted by the Election Commission of India (ECI) is increasingly leading to a clear case of disenfranchisement in several parts of India. Marauding on after a judgment by the Supreme Court of India allowed it to proceed, the SIR has now struck out a fifth of the names from the electoral rolls in Telangana and Karnataka – nearly 22% and 19.5% respectively – and among the highest in the country. The cuts are steepest in their capital cities – five constituencies in Bengaluru have lost more than half of their electors while nine of Hyderabad's 15 have seen deletions of more than 40%. Cuts of this kind cannot simply be a trimming of bloated rolls at the margins. If they are accurate, the ECI's own summary revision processes were yielding bloated rolls in recent elections, and doing so in the very places with high net in-migration from the rest of India. And if the deletions are to be justified, those struck off the rolls must have left the States – a move within Karnataka or Telangana would only relocate a voter's name on the same State roll, not remove it altogether. Yet, this is neither borne out by recent survey data nor by the government's own population estimates.

During the Bihar SIR, the Court asked why political parties had filed so few objections, seeking inclusion of wrongly deleted names; that question might hold true for the Southern States as well. A plausible reason could be that the voter id is useful to a citizen only once in a few years, leading to less alacrity on their part. This may explain why a process that puts the onus on electors yields cuts of this scale. Meanwhile, proving a smoking gun in the data is difficult because of the ECI's opacity. It has not published the elector-to-population ratio for any State so far during the revision even though doing so is mandatory and is the only test of under-enrolment. The Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer has not even bothered to release a gender-wise breakdown of the deletions, instead scattering the lists across several Google Drive links without the old booth numbers, making verification arduous. The outcome of such shoddiness is visible in West Bengal, where the ECI's dubious "logical discrepancy" process disenfranchised lakhs of electors, forcing them to seek redress before tribunals set up under the aegis of the Court. Months after the elections, records obtained under a Right to Information request show that barely 82,000 of the nearly 38 lakh appeals before the 19 tribunals have been decided, with more than 90% of those decisions favouring electors seeking restoration. The ECI – an institution once envied even by wealthier democracies for bringing large numbers of Indians to the polling booth – is now an obstacle to universal adult franchise.

Deferred rivalry

Injuries are coming in the way of anticipated matchups in the US Open

The Carlos Alcaraz-Jannik Sinner rivalry is no doubt this era's defining matchup, but it has also been punctuated by long pauses. In early 2025, Sinner was absent for three months as he served a doping-related ban; this season, Alcaraz was out of action for four months from mid-April owing to a troublesome wrist. Just when it seemed that the two leading lights will come face to face at the US Open starting Sunday, Sinner has been waylaid by a knee injury. In 2025, they met six times in six months; there has just been a solitary duel in the subsequent nine. In a way, the postponement of the battle may suit Alcaraz, for the seven-time Major champion has not played a competitive singles fixture since Barcelona in April. The Spaniard has warmed up for Flushing Meadows with two mixed doubles matches partnering the legendary Serena Williams, but a best-of-five-sets contest is a significant step-up. The 23-year-old will open against Roman Safiullin – a tricky player who beat Alcaraz in 2023 on a Paris hard-court and reached the Wimbledon fourth round this year – and is drawn to meet the in-form American Ben Shelton in the quarterfinal. Potential semifinal opponents include 24-time Slam titlist Novak Djokovic and 2021 US Open winner Daniil Medvedev, which makes the defending champion's path challenging.

However, Djokovic and Medvedev are on their own tough journeys. The 39-year-old Serb is no longer the once-renowned hard-court master, and lost his lone match - in Cincinnati - after the semifinal reverse to Sinner at Wimbledon. Medvedev was last in a Major final at the 2024 Australian Open and is without a trophy since February. Alexander Zverev thus has a golden opportunity to make his big breakthrough on his favourite surface. Without Sinner, the German will be the top seed, and following the French Open triumph and Wimbledon runner-up finish, the 29-year-old will be confidence personified. Among women, two-time defending champion Aryna Sabalenka would have liked to be that player, but the Belarusian World No. 1 has wobbled of late and seen her lead at the top cut to less than 450 points. Her chief challenger Elena Rybakina may be racing against time to recover from an ankle injury, but with Iga Swiatek, Coco Gauff and Jessica Pegula all in impressive form leading into New York, Sabalenka will have a daunting task. Wimbledon winner Linda Noskova will be looking for a worthy follow-up while the fast-rising 21-year-old from the Philippines, Alexandra Eala, will hope to continue her recent eye-popping run. With Serena and Venus Williams set to pair up in doubles, there will be a rich sprinkling of stardust too.

For a people long regarded as at the crossroads of civilisations, the past five years of the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan (IEA) under Taliban rule resemble the backwaters. After 47 years of bloodletting, terrorism and foreign occupation, the current “stability” is a respite. But the ongoing time-freeze only postpones an eventual transition to modern universality. So far, the process has been glacial and selective, causing pain and uncertainty. It is time to take stock of the past half-decade and try to fix the broad contours of a foreseeable future.

A more stable country

The IEA's overall performance since the August 15, 2021 takeover has been a binary. On the positive side, though the IEA 2.0 transition was as chaotic as the IEA 1.0 transition in 1996, it spared the country from mass retribution. Afghanistan is now largely stable and secure. The country's “Badlands” were long associated with militant groups such as al-Qaeda. Their 9/11 attacks unleashed two decades of bloody U.S. retribution on both al-Qaeda and the IEA 1.0. The IEA 2.0 has disallowed the use of their territory for operations against other countries. During the past five years, an estimated 5.7 million refugees from Pakistan and Iran have returned to Afghanistan. While this return of an eighth of the country's population has exacerbated the penury, the government has managed it reasonably well. These unmistakable shifts from the ruinous policies of the previous Islamic Emirate (1996-2001) have partially mitigated the world's concerns.

But many of the IEA 2.0 domestic policies are a carbon copy of IEA 1.0; its socio-political contrast with the preceding western-designed Republic was widely perceived as a huge regression. To the universal abomination, Taliban 2.0 swiftly reinstated the harshest rules in the contemporary Islamic world: a ban on music, no education for girls beyond class six, gender segregation, lifting the ban on child marriages and a narrow power base shutting out women, non-Pashtuns and ethnic minorities. The Taliban theocrats defended these measures, citing Islamic Sharia, Sunni Deobandi Islam, Hanafi jurisprudence and Pashtun traditions.

The West, in particular, felt deeply betrayed by the Taliban's cynical disregard for their commitments under the transitional accord signed in Doha in 2020 to pave the way for U.S. and North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) troop withdrawal. Two decades of the U.S. military campaign against the Taliban, which caused 6,379 deaths and cost \$2.26 trillion in expenses, now seem in vain. Despite intense Pakistani lobbying for the IEA 2.0 to be accepted and formally recognised, there was global unanimity to withhold both till such draconian policies were moderated. The global community's response to the Taliban's re-takeover was framed by the United Nations



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A fortnight ago, the Taliban completed five years in power, bringing stability; but Afghans still yearn for a political, economic and social makeover

Security Council resolution 2593 adopted on August 30, 2021. It demanded, *inter alia*, that Afghan territory not be used for terrorism and that human rights, including the rights of women, children, and minorities, be upheld. It also encouraged all parties to seek an inclusive, negotiated political settlement, with the full, equal, and meaningful participation of women, that responds to the desire of Afghans to sustain and build on the gains Afghanistan had made over the preceding 20 years, in adherence to the rule of law. Five years on, this resolution remains a cornerstone of global policy on the IEA.

The IEA 2.0's political architecture of an uncodified unitary theocracy evolved informally from the Quetta Shura, later called Rahbari Shura. It received the endorsement of 3,000 Afghan clerics and tribal leaders under the aegis of a Loya Jirga (Grand Assembly) held in Kabul in mid-2022. Accordingly, Hibatullah Akhundzada was appointed Supreme Leader (Amir al-Mu'minin), with combined powers as head of state, commander-in-chief, and religious leader of Afghanistan. He heads the 26-member Leadership Council, the IEA 2.0's top decision-making body, which includes Prime Minister Hassan Akhund and three Deputy Leaders. Its decisions are implemented by the Cabinet. The IEA 2.0 has often cited the Holy Koran as its Constitution and Hanafi jurisprudence as its common law.

Fragile economic progress

The latest available figures are tentative, but point to a relative improvement in the Afghan economy. Draconian measures have curbed rampant corruption and smuggling. Thanks to better fiscal discipline, the national currency, the Afghani, is stable. Consumer inflation was 2% in 2025. The Nominal GDP is \$19.66 billion, contributed by services (49%), agriculture (26%), manufacturing and mining (13%) and construction (12%). Its growth rate for 2025 was 4.3% and is expected to be 2.3% in 2026. The country's GDP dropped by nearly 20% following the Taliban's return to power. The GDP/capita is only \$448, less than one-sixth of India's.

Nearly half of Afghanistan's 49 million population lives under the national poverty line, facing acute food shortages. Still, most western official development assistance (ODA) remains suspended, and many multilateral agencies restrict their funding. Some non-governmental organisations have continued to help mitigate the dire situation. The population rose by 11% in 2025, largely due to immigration. This led to a 4% decline in GDP per capita despite healthy economic growth. Afghanistan has a Human Development Index (HDI) score of 0.496, among the world's lowest. Formal unemployment is put at 13.3%, with most women and a quarter of young men jobless. While foreign trade reached \$13.9 billion in 2025, Afghan exports barely cover 15% of its imports. Despite a rise in tax revenues, negligible foreign investments and declining

A shared disaster, beyond borders and geopolitics

On Wednesday, August 26, 2026, at approximately 8.44 a.m. Nepal time, what initially appeared to be a 4.4-magnitude earthquake struck near the Nepal-China border. It triggered the collapse of an enormous glacial slab, which plunged a kilometre below to the valley floor, resulting in devastating flash floods. The United States Geological Survey later confirmed that the seismic activity was, in fact, the glacial collapse itself and the landslide (later registered as equivalent to an earthquake measuring 5.2) rather than by tectonic shifts. Preliminary estimates suggest that 579 people have perished in Nepal, with nearly 2,000 people missing, many of them believed to be foreigners.

Entire villages and towns that this writer has previously travelled through have been swept away. Vital infrastructure, such as bridges and hydropower stations, has been completely decimated. A staggering 475 megawatts of generating capacity has been wiped off Nepal's electricity grid. This may go down as the most devastating natural disaster Nepal has ever witnessed.

Nature's fury knows no borders

For Nepal and its two neighbours, India and China, which ordinarily see themselves caught up in geopolitical contestations in the country, the catastrophic force of Mother Nature is a reminder that the political dimensions of geography are relevant only insofar as nature does not intervene, unexpectedly and destructively. The natural world does not recognise political boundaries in the same way that the custodians of nation-states do. China and India both suffered substantial losses from Wednesday's floods. Human and property losses continue to mount in all three countries, including Nepal.

China's Gyirong Port, the largest land trade



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For Nepal, India and China, the devastating cross-border floods are a stark reminder of nature's fury, and that cooperation must transcend the boundaries of geopolitics

port in the Tibet Autonomous Region and the primary gateway between Nepal and China, was designated an international-standard land port. An upgrade in August 2017 led to its transformation, upgrading it from a bilateral crossing to a fully recognised international gateway.

Built at a cost of \$175.8 million, the port and the services it provided are now effectively buried beneath heavy sediment and debris.

Access roads on the Chinese side leading to the Nepal border, as well as power supplies and local communication links, have been completely severed or severely damaged. There are reports of fatalities on the Chinese side – a number that is almost certain to rise. There are also reports of people missing in Tibet's Gyirong County, including foreign nationals.

The loss of human life for India is tragic, with the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) confirming that Indian nationals are missing or untraced. Most of them were tourists-cum-pilgrims headed to the abode of Lord Shiva at Kailash Mansarovar. This is a route this writer has travelled on more than a few occasions. The pilgrims would have driven from Kathmandu through the lush, rocky and distinctly narrow river valley to reach Gyirong Port, before proceeding further upwards to the majestic Tibetan Plateau.

Flood fallout for India

For India, the downstream flood threats to its States have been severe, although the immediate threat from some of these events may have passed. Floodwaters reached the Gandak, Kosi and Ganga rivers in Bihar, prompting authorities in Patna to go on maximum alert and deploy large teams, particularly to the Valmikinagar Barrage and along vulnerable embankments, to monitor alarmingly high water levels. Riverside

external grants leave the government with insignificant funds for welfare or decrepit infrastructure mauled by nearly five decades of instability. After the formation of IEA 2.0 in 2021, the U.S. froze \$9.6 billion worth of Afghanistan's foreign assets.

During the past five years, the IEA 2.0 has sought international acceptance and legitimacy without undertaking the necessary domestic reforms. Nevertheless, the ostracising consensus has frayed, and realpolitik has spurred engagement. The IEA now claims to have 40 active diplomatic missions abroad and more than 20 countries represented in Kabul, even as Russia is so far the only country to have recognised the IEA and opened an embassy in Kabul. Pakistan, China, Iran and India have established links with Kabul at variously nuanced *de jure* levels without extending formal recognition. Some trade and mineral exploitation transactions have also been made. Iran, the Central Asian Republics, the Gulf countries and Türkiye have extended trade and logistical links. With the solitary exception of neighbouring Pakistan, with which it is in conflict, Afghanistan's links with most regional countries are stable.

New Delhi's Afghan engagement

India was initially sceptical of the IEA 2.0, but has since come full circle. New Delhi continues to conform to global norms by not having full diplomatic recognition, without preventing substantive bilateral engagement. Following the Afghan Foreign Minister's successful visit to India in October 2025, three other Afghan Ministers have also visited India. Despite Pakistan's denial of overland transit, India-Afghan annual trade has hovered around one billion dollars, with India becoming one of the largest markets for Afghan exports. India has provided the IEA with valuable humanitarian assistance. Indian mentoring has improved the Afghan cricket team's performance.

With five years of governance behind them, some IEA leaders are beginning to see the unsustainability of their headline domestic socio-political agenda. For instance, the Taliban now claim that the ban on higher education for girls is due to a lack of funds for segregated education. The need of the hour now is for the world community to encourage this trend. It should collectively come up with a critical mass of incentives to gently induce the IEA to reform.

As South Asia's trendsetter, India is well suited to match mutual expectations and create a pathway for normalisation of IEA 2.0, preferably through a multilateral donors' conference. Ironically, five years ago, Pakistan tried to get the world to accept the IEA 2.0. It failed because the Taliban, then flushed with victory over the U.S., saw no need to adopt. In case India decides to take up this “great game”, New Delhi would need to gingerly begin at both ends. A progressive and moderate Afghanistan, thus created, would be an asset not only to India but also to the world at large.

communities were evacuated to safer locations. Authorities in Uttar Pradesh also went on alert, with the State's Relief Commissioner tracking developments in real time, as overflowing rivers from Nepal naturally flow into Indian territory.

Border districts such as Maharajganj and Kushinagar stepped up emergency surveillance and deployed emergency personnel. India's National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) deployed teams across the Bihar-Uttar Pradesh border area. New Delhi also activated an extensive Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief programme. The Indian Air Force dispatched more than 47.5 tonnes of emergency relief material to Nepal, including medical supplies, rations and tents.

A case for cooperation

All of this underscores how severely this calamitous event has affected all three countries – Nepal, India and China. The question that arises, therefore, is how to transcend some of the parochial features of geopolitics, while by no means ignoring the compulsions of realpolitik, and create a feasible framework for collaboration and coordination.

There is little doubt that Nepal, India and China will need to effectively address increasingly unpredictable cross-border natural phenomena such as the one we have just witnessed. There is equally little doubt that such events are likely to recur in the future.

The past few days have underscored the need to find ways to compartmentalise the harder political dynamics of the China-India-Nepal relationship and create space for cooperation when confronted with events that remind us of the fickleness of nature, the fragility of human life, and the physical interconnections that inextricably link the three countries.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A climate frontline

The disturbing pictures emerging from Nepal and the affected regions show the enormous destruction caused by end-glacial lake outburst floods (EGLOFs) and other extreme natural events. Rising temperatures, melting glaciers, erratic rainfall and environmental degradation are increasing

the vulnerability of the Himalayan regions. Stronger climate policies, sustainable development, protection of forests and rivers, and disaster-preparedness measures are essential. Nepal and its neighbours must act collectively before nature sends even stronger warnings. **Md Sabir Hussain**, Arrah, Bihar

The devastation has exposed the vulnerability of communities living in one of the world's most fragile mountain ecosystems. It is a grim reminder of how rapidly natural disasters can turn into humanitarian catastrophes. The immediate priority must be rescue, relief and rehabilitation. Saving human lives, however,

requires moving from disaster response to disaster prevention. Countries sharing these mountains and glaciers — India, China, Pakistan, Nepal and Bhutan — should coordinate to keep people safe across borders. India and China, in particular, must demonstrate that saving human lives and protecting the environment

can transcend political differences. **Gregory Fernandes**, Mumbai

The disaster has prompted explanations, including avalanches, earthquakes, Chinese dam releases, western disturbances, intense rainfall and glacial lake outbursts. Determining the precise cause will

require rigorous scientific investigation, although political considerations and inadequate reporting may complicate the assessment. The broader lesson is clear: ecological disruption can intensify natural hazards. **R.S. Narula**, Patiala, Punjab

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